

HER LAST RALLY

Having recently announced that this will be her last season on tour, tennis star **SANIA MIRZA** has shown that it is always best to call it a day when the going is good

PTI

Q. What prompted your announcement to retire at the end of the season?
It wasn't something that was really planned. I have been thinking about it for the past few months. I have been struggling a bit with my body, also mentally. In hindsight, though, I feel like I have made so many people sad because I am now constantly being asked about retirement after every match.

Q. Who has been your favourite doubles/ mixed doubles partner and why?
I'm going to have to say it was Martina (Hingis). We had a lot of fun on and off the court, created some special memories and some very special records. In mixed, I think it's Mahesh (Bhupathi), because we were the first Indian woman and man to win a Grand Slam together. We are very close friends and that made it even more special.

Q. The French Open title is missing from your tally when it comes to doubles and Wimbledon in the mixed doubles...
I think I'm all in for the next one year and I look forward to winning as much as I can. I feel like I'm a contender every time I play. If it happens, it will be really amazing. But I'm sure even if I pull it off, I'll always have something else I want to achieve. That's just the way an athlete's mentality goes.

Q. What would you tell a little girl who dreams of playing at the Grand Slams and Olympics?
'Don't let anybody tell you that you can't do it'. When we are young, we don't choose the profession we want because of society's norms. When we become older, we are expected to get married, have kids. These norms mean nothing. So, what I want to say to that little girl is, 'Back yourself so much that you don't need anyone else to back you'.

–with Shail Desai